This was the moment that Gary Slaughter, the communications officer on the USS *Cony*, recalled so vividly decades later. The Soviet naval officers he saw on the bridge were Savitsky and Arkhipov. Savitsky ordered that the red state flag, not that of the Soviet Navy, be raised to indicate that the submarine belonged to the USSR. The Soviets remembered their first direct encounter with the Americans more or less the same way as Slaughter. “When the vessel came up and took its position, the chief of staff of the brigade [Arkhipov], the commander of the submarine [Savitsky], and the signals officer with his searchlight came onto the bridge,” wrote Mikhailov decades later. “In spite of the dark southern night, it was as bright as day on the bridge because of the searchlights trained on it by the anti-submarine defense planes,” wrote Leonenko, echoing him.[18]

But the Soviets also remembered something that Slaughter did not: the American airplanes were threatening and harassing the slow-moving Soviet submarine. “They flew low down the length of the submarine and, illuminating it with their searchlights, fired tracer bullets ahead of it,” recalled Mikhailov. “The US anti-submarine defense planes, their searchlights on, circled the submarine from the right in hedge-hopping maneuver and, approaching the deck, opened fire with such force that voice communications at the central post were drowned out by the roar of the cannonade,” wrote Leonenko.[19]

It was after the episode described by Slaughter, with a US Navy plane dropping flares to get a better photo of the submarine, that Savitsky and the others on the bridge panicked and decided that they were under attack. “Emergency dive! Prepare torpedo tubes 1 and 2 for firing!” Leonenko, who was in charge of the torpedoes, wrote, recalling the order that Savitsky gave after climbing down from the bridge. This time Savitsky was ready to use his nuclear torpedo. His previous order had concerned regular torpedoes, but this one referred to the nuclear weapon. “This order was intended for the first compartment, and tube no. 1 contained the nuclear-armed torpedo,” remembered Leonenko. The forward torpedo tubes that Slaughter recalled being turned toward the USS *Cony* included tube no. 1.

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